New Client Packet

[Practice Name] · Christian Belief Counseling · [Address] · [Phone] · [Email/Website]

Welcome. Please complete this packet before your first session. It takes about 20–30 minutes. You can type your answers right in this PDF, save it, and email it back, or print it and bring it with you. You may skip any question in Section 3 you do not wish to answer; we can talk about it in session. This form is not monitored continuously and should not be used to request emergency assistance. If you are in danger, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department; for a mental-health crisis, call or text 988.

1. CLIENT INFORMATION

Full name: _____ Date of birth: _____

Preferred name: _____ Pronouns (optional): _____ Sex: _____

Street address: _____

City: _____ State: _____ ZIP: _____

Cell phone: _____ Other phone: _____

Email: _____

Preferred contact: ☐ Cell call ☐ Text ☐ Email ☐ Other phone

OK to leave a detailed message? ☐ Cell voicemail ☐ Text ☐ Email ☐ Other phone ☐ No – call-back request only

Relationship status: ☐ Single ☐ Married/partnered ☐ Separated/divorced ☐ Widowed ☐ Other

Living situation: ☐ Alone ☐ With partner/family ☐ Shared or supported housing ☐ Unstable housing ☐ Other

Employer/school (optional): _____ Occupation: _____

Emergency contact

Name: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone: _____ Alternate phone: _____

May we contact this person in an emergency? ☐ Yes ☐ No

How did you hear about us? _____

2. INSURANCE AND PHOTO ID

How will you pay? ☐ Insurance ☐ Self-pay ☐ Out-of-network (I will file my own claims)

Primary insurance

Insurance company: _____ Phone on card: _____

Member ID: _____ Group #: _____

Is the client the policyholder? ☐ Yes ☐ No – complete below

Policyholder name: _____ Policyholder DOB: _____

Relationship to client: _____ Policyholder employer: _____

Secondary insurance (if any)

☐ None

Insurance company: _____ Member ID: _____

Group #: _____ Policyholder name / DOB / relationship: _____

Photos of your cards

Using your cellphone, take clear photos (flat surface, good light, all four corners showing) of:

- FRONT of your insurance card(s)
- BACK of your insurance card(s)
- FRONT of your driver's license or other photo ID

Photos cannot be attached inside this PDF. Email them along with this form, upload them where the online form asks, or bring the cards to your first session to be copied.

Photos: ☐ Emailed / uploaded ☐ Will bring to first session ☐ Self-pay – insurance not needed

3. BRIEF ADULT HISTORY

Please do not enter the names of other people. You may skip any question you do not wish to answer.

Present concerns

What are the main concerns for which you are seeking help?

Approximately how long have these concerns been present? _____

How much are they interfering with your daily life? ☐ Slightly ☐ Moderately ☐ Seriously ☐ Extremely

What would you most like to change or accomplish?

Current difficulties – check any that currently apply

☐ Anxiety, fear, or panic

☐ Anger or irritability

☐ Relationship or family problems

☐ Unwanted thoughts or repetitive behaviors

☐ Unusually elevated mood, impulsivity, or little need for sleep

☐ Work, school, financial, housing, or legal stress

☐ Other: _____

☐ Depression, sadness, or loss of interest

☐ Grief or loss

☐ Traumatic experiences or distressing memories

☐ Problems with sleep, appetite, energy, or concentration

☐ Hearing, seeing, or strongly believing things others do not

☐ Spiritual or religious concerns

Safety

Are you currently thinking about killing or seriously harming yourself? ☐ No ☐ Yes

Have you ever attempted suicide or intentionally seriously harmed yourself? ☐ No ☐ Yes

Are you currently thinking about seriously harming someone else? ☐ No ☐ Yes

Do you presently feel unsafe, threatened, abused, controlled, or exploited by anyone? ☐ No ☐ Yes

Do you currently have access to a firearm or another potentially lethal means? ☐ No ☐ Yes

If you answered "Yes" to any safety question, please tell your counselor right away. If danger is imminent, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department. You can also call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline) at any time.

Treatment and health history

Have you previously received counseling, psychiatric treatment, or hospitalization? ☐ No ☐ Yes

If yes, briefly describe what was helpful or unhelpful:

Current medications (emotional, psychiatric, sleep, pain, substance-related, or other) – name and dose:

Prescriber: _____ Phone: _____

Primary care physician: _____ Phone: _____

Any medical, neurological, hormonal, sleep-related, or pain condition that may affect your emotional health? ☐ No ☐ Yes

If yes: _____

Have close biological relatives experienced significant mental-health or substance-use problems? ☐ No ☐ Yes ☐ Unsure

Alcohol and other substances

During the past year, has your use of alcohol, cannabis, prescription medication, or another substance concerned you or someone close to you, become difficult to control, or caused health, relationship, work, legal, or spiritual problems?

☐ No ☐ Yes

If yes, briefly explain: _____

Important life experiences

Have you experienced abuse, neglect, violence, disaster, combat, serious loss, discrimination, or another event that continues to affect you?

☐ No ☐ Yes ☐ Prefer not to answer

Faith and support (optional)

Are religious faith, spiritual beliefs, or a faith community important to understanding your concerns or helping you address them? ☐ No ☐ Yes ☐ Unsure

Faith background / church (optional): _____

If yes, how should faith be included in counseling? _____

Who or what presently provides you with meaningful support?

What personal strengths, coping methods, relationships, or beliefs have helped you?

Is there anything else important for us to know before we meet?

4. INFORMED CONSENT FOR TREATMENT

Nature of counseling. Counseling is a collaborative process in which you and your counselor work together to understand your concerns and to make changes in thinking, feelings, behavior, relationships, and spiritual life. The first session(s) focus on assessment and setting goals together. Counseling often helps, but results cannot be guaranteed, and talking about painful matters may at times feel uncomfortable before it feels better.

Faith-integrated approach. [Practice Name] offers Christian Belief Counseling, a cognitive-behavioral approach that helps identify beliefs that shape how you interpret life events and examine them for accuracy. For clients who desire it, biblical truth and Christian faith are integrated into counseling. Faith integration is your choice; you may ask for more, less, or none at any time, and you will be treated with respect whatever your beliefs.

Confidentiality and its limits. What you share is kept confidential and is not released without your written permission, except in a few situations the law requires or permits (such as a serious risk of harm, suspected abuse or neglect, a court order, and insurance billing). These limits, and your choices about them, are explained in full in Section 5, Confidentiality and Limits of Confidentiality Agreement, which you will initial and sign. The uses for treatment, payment, and health-care operations are described in the Notice of Privacy Practices (Section 6).

Emergencies and after-hours. [Practice Name] is not a crisis service and messages are not monitored after hours. In an emergency, call 911 or go to the nearest emergency department. For a mental-health crisis, call or text 988. For non-urgent matters, call [Phone]; messages are returned within [one business day].

Counselor credentials. Your counselor's name, state of practice, license, and supervisor (if any) are listed under "Your counselor" at the start of Section 5. You may ask about training and approach at any time.

[Check your state board rules: some states require a specific disclosure statement and the board's contact information for complaints.]

Your rights, including the right to stop. You have the right to ask questions, to take part in planning your treatment, to refuse any technique, and to stop counseling at any time. If you stop, a referral can be provided on request.

Records. Records are kept securely and retained as required by law; see Section 5.9 for how long records are kept and who can see them.

I have read this information, have had the opportunity to ask questions, and consent to counseling services with [Practice Name].

Client (or parent/guardian) signature: _____ Date: _____

Printed name: _____ Initials: _____

[Check your state board rules: if the client is a minor, parent/guardian consent rules and the age at which a minor may consent.]

5. CONFIDENTIALITY AND LIMITS OF CONFIDENTIALITY AGREEMENT

Your counselor *(filled in by the practice)*

Counselor name: _____ State of practice: _____

License type & # (if applicable): _____

Supervisor name (if applicable): _____ Supervisor license #: _____

Trust is the cornerstone of counseling. This agreement explains how I protect your privacy, the few times the law or ethics require me to share information, and your rights. Please read it, initial where asked, and sign before our first session. We will go over it together, and you can ask questions at any time.

5.1 What confidentiality means

All interactions that take place in counseling are considered confidential. This includes phone calls and messages, scheduling notes, what you say in session, and my records and notes. I will not even confirm that you are my client unless you give me written permission. In almost all cases, I share information about you only when you give me written permission.

5.2 Who can see your records

Your records are seen by me [and by office staff who help with scheduling and billing, who are trained in and bound by the same privacy rules]. If I practice under supervision, my supervisor may also see them (see Section 5.3). No one else sees them unless you give written permission or one of the exceptions in Section 5.3 applies. If I keep separate personal session notes ("psychotherapy notes"), federal law (HIPAA) gives them extra protection, and they are not shared even with your insurance company without your separate written permission.

5.3 When I may have to share information

These rules are based on the laws of the state of practice listed under “Your counselor” above, where I provide counseling. I will keep what you share private except in these situations. When I must share, I share only what is truly necessary and, whenever it is safe and possible, I will talk with you first.

- **Danger to yourself.** If I believe you are in serious and immediate danger of killing or seriously injuring yourself, I may contact your emergency contact, family members, or emergency services, or help arrange hospitalization, to keep you safe.
- **Danger to others.** If you threaten serious harm to another person, I may be required or permitted to warn that person, notify the police, or arrange hospitalization (often called the "duty to warn or protect"). [State] law sets the exact rules.
- **Abuse or neglect of a child.** If I learn of or suspect physical, sexual, or emotional abuse or neglect of anyone under 18, I must report it to child protective services. I do not have to be certain; reasonable suspicion is enough.
- **Abuse of an elder or dependent adult.** If I learn of or suspect abuse, neglect, or exploitation of an elder [age __ or older in [State]] or a disabled or dependent adult, I must report it to the state agency that handles these reports.
- **Court orders and subpoenas.** If a judge orders me to release records or to testify, I may have to comply. I will ask for your written consent first, or work to limit what is shared as narrowly as possible. I will not hand over records just because an attorney asks; I will talk with you, and with an attorney if needed, before responding to any subpoena.
- **Insurance billing.** If you use insurance, I share only the minimum needed to be paid: usually your name, dates of service, type of service, and diagnosis, and sometimes a treatment summary if your plan requires it. You authorize this in Section 7 of this packet. If you pay in full yourself, you may ask me not to bill your insurance at all.
- **Consultation and supervision.** I may consult with other licensed professionals to give you the best care, without using your name or details that would identify you; they must also keep it confidential. If I practice under supervision, the supervisor named under “Your counselor” above may review your records and information as part of that supervision and is bound by the same confidentiality rules as I am.
- **Emergencies.** In a medical or mental-health emergency, I may share information that emergency responders need to help you.
- **Other legal requirements.** Rarely, other laws may require disclosure (for example, certain public-health reports, or if you file a complaint or lawsuit against me).

Talking about a past crime, when no one is in ongoing danger, generally does not require a report. If you are an adult being hurt by a partner or family member, I usually cannot report it without your permission [check [State] law], but we will make a safety plan together.

5.4 Faith-integrated counseling

Christian Belief Counseling may include prayer, Scripture, or conversation about faith, but only if you want it. You may ask for more, less, or none at any time, and you will be respected whatever your beliefs. I will not share anything about your counseling with your church, pastor, ministry leaders, or faith community, even if they referred you or help pay for counseling, unless you sign a written release.

5.5 Couples and family counseling

When I see a couple or family together, the couple or family is "the client." I cannot promise that other participants will keep what is said private. Records of joint sessions are released only with the written permission of every adult participant. Please choose one (every adult taking part signs at the end):

☐ No-secrets policy: something one person tells me privately may be brought into joint sessions if it is important to our work (I will first encourage you to share it yourself)

☐ Private information shared with me alone stays private unless it falls under Section 5.3

☐ Not applicable – individual counseling

[Brian: choose a default policy, or offer both options as shown.]

5.6 Children and teens [if applicable]

[If you counsel minors:] Parents or legal guardians generally have the right to information about their child's counseling [as allowed by [State] law and custody orders]. To help a child or teen feel safe enough to open up, I will usually share general progress rather than details, unless there is a safety concern. I need consent from a parent or guardian with legal authority to approve treatment; in joint custody, both parents' consent may be needed [check [State] law and the custody papers].

5.7 Email, text, phone, and video sessions

Email and text messages are convenient but not fully secure, and others may see them on your phone or computer. Please use them for scheduling only, not for personal or clinical details. Video sessions use a secure platform, but no technology is free of risk. Join from a private place, use your own device and a password-protected network (not public Wi-Fi), and do not record sessions. I do not provide counseling or crisis help by email or text.

You may contact me by: ☐ Phone call ☐ Voicemail ☐ Text ☐ Email ☐ Secure portal [if offered]

5.8 Technology and AI-assisted tools

I keep records in secure electronic software. I may also use secure software that includes AI-assisted tools, for example to help draft notes or paperwork, only under appropriate privacy and security safeguards and written agreements (such as a HIPAA business associate agreement). I will not enter information that identifies you into any tool without those safeguards. I do not use AI to diagnose you or to respond to a crisis, and I review and remain responsible for anything a tool produces. You may ask what tools I use, and you may decline AI-assisted tools without any effect on your care.

My choice: ☐ AI-assisted note tools may be used as described ☐ Please do not use AI-assisted tools with my information

5.9 Records and how long they are kept

Your records are stored securely [encrypted electronic records / locked files]. I keep them for [__] years after our last session [for minors: __ years after the client turns 18, whichever is longer], as required by [State] rules, and then destroy them securely. If I become unable to practice, [Records Custodian name and contact] will safeguard your records and help you get a copy.

5.10 Releasing information with your permission

Except as described in Section 5.3, I release information only with your signed written authorization (a Release of Information form) that states what will be shared, with whom, why, and when the permission ends. You may cancel it in writing at any time, except for information already shared. I share only the minimum necessary, and I remind the person who receives it that they may not pass it on without your consent.

5.11 Your rights

- See and get a copy of your records, usually within 30 days of your request (personal psychotherapy notes are an exception).
- Ask me to correct your records, or to contact you only in certain ways or at certain places.
- Ask me to limit what I share. If you pay in full yourself, I will not share that care with your insurer unless the law requires it.
- Receive a copy of my Notice of Privacy Practices, and be told if your information is ever breached.
- Make a complaint to me, to the [State Licensing Board name, phone, website], or to the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Office for Civil Rights (www.hhs.gov/ocr/complaints, 1-800-368-1019). You will never be penalized for making a complaint.

5.12 If you are in crisis

I am not a crisis service, and messages are not monitored after hours.

- Emergency or immediate danger: call 911 or go to the nearest emergency room.
- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: call or text 988, or chat at 988lifeline.org (free, 24/7; Veterans press 1).
- National Domestic Violence Hotline: 1-800-799-7233, or text START to 88788. Childhelp Child Abuse Hotline: 1-800-422-4453.
- [State] child abuse reporting line: [_____] [State] Adult Protective Services: [_____]

5.13 Acknowledgment and signatures

Please initial each statement to show you understand it:

_____ **Safety.** My counselor may share information to protect me or someone else from serious harm.

_____ **Abuse reporting.** My counselor must report suspected abuse or neglect of a child, an elder, or a dependent adult.

_____ **Legal.** A court order or other law may require my counselor to release information.

_____ **Insurance.** If I use insurance, the minimum information needed for billing will be shared.

_____ **Consultation and supervision.** My counselor may consult with professionals without using my name, and a supervisor named above (if any) may review my information under the same confidentiality rules.

_____ **Electronic.** Email, text, and video have privacy risks, and I chose my contact methods above.

_____ **Technology.** I understand how secure software and AI-assisted tools may be used, and I made my choice above.

_____ **Faith community.** Nothing will be shared with my church or pastor without my written release.

I have read this agreement, have had the chance to ask questions, and understand the nature and limits of confidentiality. I agree to begin counseling with this understanding.

_____ _____

Client signature Date

_____

Printed name

_____ _____

Parent/guardian signature (if client is a minor) Date

_____

Printed name

_____ _____

Other adult participant (couples/family) Date

_____

Printed name

_____ _____

Counselor signature Date

6. ACKNOWLEDGMENT OF RECEIPT – NOTICE OF PRIVACY PRACTICES

I acknowledge that I have received, or have been offered, a copy of the [Practice Name] Notice of Privacy Practices, which describes how my health information may be used and disclosed and how I can get access to it.

Client (or parent/guardian) signature: _____ Date: _____

Printed name: _____ Initials: _____

Office use only – if acknowledgment could not be obtained, reason: _____ Staff initials: _____

7. FINANCIAL POLICY, ASSIGNMENT OF BENEFITS & AUTHORIZATION TO BILL INSURANCE

Initial assessment session (90791)	$[____]
Individual session, 53+ minutes (90837)	$[____]
Individual session, 38–52 minutes (90834)	$[____]
Late cancellation / no-show fee	$[____]

Please initial each item:

_____ Payment, copays, coinsurance and deductibles are due at the time of each session. Accepted methods: [_____].

_____ Insurance benefits are verified as a courtesy, but this is not a guarantee of payment. I am responsible for any amount my insurance does not pay, including denied claims and services not covered.

_____ Cancellations need at least [24] hours' notice. Late cancellations and missed appointments (no-shows) are charged the fee above; insurance does not pay this fee.

_____ Assignment of benefits: I authorize my insurance company to pay benefits directly to [Practice Name / counselor] for services provided.

_____ Authorization to bill insurance: I authorize [Practice Name] to release the information needed to process my insurance claims, including diagnosis, dates of service, and treatment information.

_____ Fees for other services (letters, reports, records copies, court-related work) are billed at $[____] per hour and are not covered by insurance.

[Check your state board rules and payer contracts: no-show fee limits for in-network/Medicaid clients and records-copy fee limits.]

Client or responsible party signature: _____ Date: _____

Printed name: _____ Initials: _____

8. TELEHEALTH CONSENT (ONLY IF YOU WILL HAVE VIDEO OR PHONE SESSIONS)

☐ I will NOT use telehealth – skip this section ☐ I would like the option of telehealth

Telehealth means counseling by secure video or phone instead of in person. It uses a HIPAA-compliant platform, but no technology is completely free of risk, such as interruptions or unauthorized access. I agree to:

- Be located in [State] during each session and tell my counselor my location at the start of each session.
- Use a private place where I will not be overheard, and not record sessions without mutual consent.
- If the connection fails, wait for the counselor to call me back at: _____.
- In an emergency during a session, my counselor may contact local emergency services at my location. Emergency contact near me: _____.

I understand that I may stop telehealth at any time and request in-person services, and that telehealth may not be right for every situation. Telehealth sessions follow the same fees, confidentiality, and policies as in-person sessions.

[Check your state board rules: telehealth-specific consent, the client's-location licensure rules, and any interstate compact (Counseling Compact) status.]

Client (or parent/guardian) signature: _____ Date: _____

Printed name: _____ Initials: _____

9. GOOD FAITH ESTIMATE NOTICE (SELF-PAY OR OUT-OF-NETWORK CLIENTS)

Under the federal No Surprises Act, if you do not have health insurance, or you are not using insurance to pay for services, you have the right to receive a Good Faith Estimate of the expected cost of your care. You may ask for one before scheduling, and you will receive it in writing at least 1 business day before your first session. If you receive a bill that is at least $400 more than your Good Faith Estimate, you can dispute the bill. Make sure to save a copy of your Good Faith Estimate. For questions or more information, visit www.cms.gov/nosurprises or call 1-800-985-3059.

☐ I am self-pay / out-of-network and have received a Good Faith Estimate ☐ Not applicable – I am using in-network insurance

Client (or parent/guardian) signature: _____ Date: _____

Printed name: _____ Initials: _____

Thank you. We look forward to meeting you.